



How to Deploy a Web Server in Less Than Five Minutes

If you're in a real hurry, you can skip the background, and just read the warning and 'What to do' (but you'll miss the fun part).

I was working at a firm, which I will refer to as Acme Corporation (for reasons of confidentiality). My hiring brief had been unusually brief—build 14 servers.

"I wonder what I'll be doing the second week," I thought. Initially, the contract was for one month, but somewhere along the line, before I had even signed up, that turned into three. Unsurprisingly, the building of 14 servers was merely one project. The reality was that I was filling in for one person who had left, and another, Kevin, who was going on long-service leave for 3 months.

There was some documentation for building the servers, but, as in most organisations, the documentation relied on substantial amounts of in-house knowledge—the sort of knowledge that is acquired over time. I had three days to learn the ropes before

Kevin left. The job entailed building virtual machines (VMs). For practice, I built machines and destroyed them; and built yet more machines to different specs, before destroying those too.

On the third day, we agreed that I would be fine in Kevin's absence. After all, there were others in the department who could answer my questions.

As soon as Kevin left, the difficulties began. I had been building practice servers. Perhaps to build these servers I would require to consult some more detailed paper-work, which in this case, someone else had done (of course, no actual paper is involved in what I call 'paper-work'; the administration is all electronic).

Acme Corporation runs a proprietary change-management system. In theory, nothing gets built,